



HerdTrackr

Field Game Plan & Market Brief — South Africa

Offline-first cattle management · RFID ear-tag ready · 4 South African languages

July 2026 — internal discussion document

1. What HerdTrackr is

HerdTrackr is an offline-first cattle management app for iOS and Android. Full herd records — health treatments, weights, breeding and calving, pasture rotation, vaccination schedules — captured at the animal, with no signal, syncing automatically when the phone is back in range. It identifies animals three ways:

- **RFID ear tags** — scan with a Bluetooth stick reader for one-second positive ID in the crush (Unlimited plan).
- **Camera OCR** — point any normal phone at a visual ear tag and the app reads the number. No hardware needed; this is already built and working.
- **Search** — tag number, name or breed, fully offline.

The app is available in **English, Afrikaans, isiZulu and isiXhosa** — no competitor, local or international, offers this. Pricing ladder: **Starter free** (up to 50 head) · **Farm R250/m** (51–500 head) · **Unlimited R999/m** (500+ head — and the only tier with handheld RFID reader support, which is also our hardware profit line). Status: Google Play closed testing underway; Apple App Store submission prepared (screenshots, metadata and a reviewer demo account are done).

2. The market and why now

Market size

- ±12 million cattle in South Africa; roughly 25–35k commercial farming operations plus hundreds of thousands of communal/emerging cattle-keeping households.
- Emerging-farmer support programs (government, NGOs, co-ops) actively fund tools for this segment — and require local-language delivery, which only we offer.

The traceability tailwind (the big one)

Repeated FMD outbreaks have cost SA beef exports dearly and exposed the absence of a national livestock traceability system. Government is actively procuring for LITS (Livestock Identification and Traceability System) with ICAR-standard RFID button ear tags as the backbone, targeting national rollout by ±2030. Studbook launched IDTrax in May 2026 for the same reason. Every serious cattle farmer in SA will be RFID-tagging within a few years — and almost none of them own software that reads those tags. HerdTrackr already does.

Competition

Player	Strength	Weakness we exploit
BenguFarm / Stockbook (SA)	Entrenched with stud breeders	Desktop-era, English/Afrikaans only, pedigree-admin focus, weak offline mobile
Herdwatch (IRE)	Polished, 20k+ farms	Dollar/euro pricing (R600–R1,800/m equiv.), assumes connectivity, English only
AgriWebb (AUS)	Strong enterprise features	Expensive, complex, built for AUS compliance, English only
Paper + Excel	Free, familiar	The real competitor. Beaten by demos at the crush, not by ads

3. Getting farmers to adopt — the playbook

Farmers don't buy software; they copy what a respected neighbour uses. Every tactic below is built around that single fact.

3.1 Demo where the work happens

- **The crush-pen demo is the sales call.** Arrive on processing day, scan 20 animals through the chute (weigh + treat) in ten minutes, hand the farmer the phone. The product sells itself when the queue moves faster.
- Always demo the camera OCR first — “your phone already does this, no equipment needed” — then show the RFID stick as the upgrade.
- Leave the farm with the farmer's herd already loaded (bulk import from their tag register or Excel). An app with their animals in it doesn't get deleted.

3.2 Lighthouse farmers & champions

- Recruit 10–20 respected farmers across districts: free Unlimited tier for life in exchange for feedback, a testimonial, and permission to name-drop them locally.
- One champion per study group / farmers' association — the person others phone for advice. Give champions a referral reward (free months, or a branded RFID reader once the hardware program starts).
- Target the **vaccination-day and auction-day calendar**: adoption happens at gatherings, not via downloads.

3.3 Remove every excuse

- Free up to 50 head — every farmhand and small farmer can start today.
- Works offline — kills the “there's no signal on my farm” objection before it's raised.
- Their language — demo in Afrikaans/isiZulu/isiXhosa; print the one-pager in the district's language.
- Data escape hatch — export to Excel/PDF anytime. Farmers fear lock-in; make leaving easy and they'll stay.
- WhatsApp support line — farmers won't email tickets; they'll voice-note. Answer fast for the first 500 users; every solved problem is a story told at the co-op counter.

3.4 Seasonal timing

Push hardest at moments when records are top of mind: weaning and dipping seasons, pre-auction weighing, annual vaccination rounds, and financial year-end (stock counts for the accountant/bank). Plan field visits around the district's livestock calendar, not ours.

4. Sales plan — channels and targets

Channel	Angle	Mechanics
Livestock auctions	Weight history raises buyer confidence	Table + banner at 2 auctions/month; scan-a-beast demo; auctioneer gets referral fee
Vets & animal health techs	Vaccination schedules & withdrawal periods = compliance	Leave-behind cards; vet-branded protocol templates; 3-month free codes to hand out
Co-ops & feed reps	Reps visit 20+ farms/week already	Commission per activated farm; counter display at co-op till; staff demo training
Breeders' societies & study groups	Group record standards, benchmarking	Present at monthly meetings; society-wide discount code; champion per group
Emerging-farmer programs (gov/NGO)	Only tool in isiZulu/isiXhosa; training-friendly	Pitch program managers a sponsored-licence bundle + on-site training day
Agri-lenders & insurers (B2B)	Verified herd records = collateral / risk data	One pilot in year 1; hundreds of licences per signature if it lands

Funnel targets (first 18 months)

Stage	Month 3	Month 9	Month 18
Registered farms (free)	100	500	1,500
Paying farms (Farm R250 / Unlimited R999)	15 (12/3)	120 (95/25)	450+ (340/110)
MRR	R6k	R49k	R195k+
RFID readers sold (Unlimited only)	—	15–20	80–100
B2B pilots	—	1 in discussion	1–2 signed

Assumptions: ~30% of registered farms exceed the 50-animal free cap; ~40% of those convert within 90 days once a season's records are in the app. Roughly 1 in 4 paying farms runs 500+ head and lands on Unlimited — the tier that carries most of the revenue and all of the hardware attach. Churn in farm software is low (records = lock-in by value, not by force); the fight is acquisition.

5. Marketing — cheap, local, credible

- **WhatsApp first.** Farming WhatsApp groups are SA agri's real social network. Short vertical videos (30–60s): scanning a tag at the crush, weighing in the rain with no signal, isiZulu walkthrough. Shareable, no login, no ads budget.
- **Afrikaans + isiZulu content.** “Hoe om jou kudde op jou foon te bestuur” beats any English ad. One how-to video per week; captions in all four languages.
- **Ag media PR.** Landbouweekblad, Farmer's Weekly, Food For Mzansi, AgriOrbit and RSG Landbou take local-innovation stories readily — ‘SA-built app brings RFID herd records to communal farmers in isiZulu’ writes itself.
- **Facebook groups** (Boere/Veeboere groups, 50–200k members): weekly useful posts, never spam — answer record-keeping questions, drop the app when relevant.
- **Referral loop in-app:** give a month, get a month; champions tracked on a leaderboard with a yearly prize (an RFID reader).
- **Farmers' days & expos:** NAMPO (May) as the year-1 anchor; district shows quarterly. Budget: banner, table, tags, a demo steer's worth of patience.

6. The RFID hardware piece — scanners and tags

Phones cannot read livestock RFID directly: ICAR ear tags run on low-frequency 134.2 kHz (HDX/FDX-B), which phone NFC (13.56 MHz) can't see. Every competitor treats this as a problem; we treat it as the top of the product ladder: camera OCR is free for everyone, and **handheld RFID reader support is exclusive to the Unlimited tier (R999/m)**. That does three jobs at once — it gives big herds a concrete reason to be on the top tier, it makes the reader a hardware profit line we control, and it turns tags into a repeat-purchase revenue stream alongside.

6.1 Reader strategy — three phases

Phase	What	Why / economics
1. BYO reader (now)	Support Bluetooth stick readers in keyboard-wedge (HID) mode — the reader types the tag number into the scan field. Works with most readers on the market with near-zero dev work.	Zero hardware risk; farmers with existing Allflex / Tru-Test / Gallagher wands (R15–40k units) use us day one
2. Certified readers (month 3–6)	Integrate 2–3 affordable generic BLE LF readers natively (SDK/serial), test against SA tag brands, publish a ‘works with HerdTracker’ list.	Generic ICAR-compatible stick readers wholesale at R2–6k landed — an order of magnitude below the big brands

Phase	What	Why / economics
3. HerdTrackr Reader bundle (month 6+)	White-label a proven generic reader, sold only with the Unlimited plan: reader at R3,999 with an annual Unlimited subscription (R12k/yr). Rent-to-own via co-op/program partners for emerging-farmer groups.	~R1,500–2,500 hardware margin per reader + a locked-in year of the top tier; the reader is the referral prize and the co-op counter product

6.2 Tags — the repeat-purchase revenue line

- Reading stays **tag-agnostic** (any ICAR HDX/FDX-B tag, whatever LITS mandates) — but we also **resell branded HerdTrackr tag packs** sourced wholesale from an ICAR-accredited supplier, at R3–6 margin per tag.
- Tags are consumables: every calf crop needs new ones, so a 700-head Unlimited farm re-orders 150–250 tags a year — recurring hardware revenue on top of the subscription.
- **Starter kit** for new Unlimited farms: reader + 100 tags + applicator, one price, sold at the co-op counter and at auctions.
- Build a tested-compatibility matrix (tag brand × reader) during Phase 2 pilots — trust asset, SEO page, and the argument for buying our packs.
- For untagged/visual-only herds the camera OCR already covers identification — zero-hardware on-ramp, upgrade path preserved.

6.3 What to validate in the field (next 90 days)

- Buy 2–3 candidate generic BLE readers; test read range, wet/dirty tags, gloves, battery life over a full processing day.
- Confirm HID keyboard-wedge flow end-to-end in Chute Mode on both platforms.
- Price-test the bundle at auctions: does R5k with a year of software beat R18k for a name-brand wand alone? (We believe decisively yes.)

7. Market share and revenue over time

Horizon	Paying farms	~MRR (software)	Hardware + tags GP	Commercial-sector share
Year 1	100–150 (~25% Unlimited)	R35–60k	R60–120k total	<0.5%
Year 2	400–600	R160–250k	R300–500k total	~1.5–2%
Year 3	1,000–1,500 + 1–2 B2B deals	R450k+	R700k+ total	~3–5%

Costs stay minimal (solo development, cloud under R2k/m at this scale, hardware bought against orders), so the business is profitable from a few hundred subscribers. The constraint is field time, not capital. If LITS formalises earlier than 2030, these numbers are conservative — traceability compliance would make herd software a grudge purchase for every commercial farm at once, and we'd be the local, cheapest, already-RFID-ready option.

8. Risks and honest answers

Risk	Mitigation
Farmers stay on paper	Crush-pen demos + free tier + champions; paper dies one auction-day queue at a time
Big player localises (Herdwatch adds Afrikaans)	Speed + language depth + price + field presence; they won't staff SA auctions
LITS mandates a specific closed platform	Stay standards-based (ICAR), integrate early, position as the farmer-side app on top of any national registry
Solo-founder bandwidth	Ruthless focus: SA cattle only, no sheep/game/other-country detours in year 1; channel partners do the travelling
Hardware support burden	Certify few readers, sell one bundle; everything else is 'best effort HID'

9. The next 90 days

- **Weeks 1–2:** 12+ Android testers opted in (Google requirement); Apple submission in; order 3 candidate RFID readers.
- **Weeks 3–6:** First 10 lighthouse farmers signed and herds imported; reader field tests at 2 processing days; WhatsApp support line live.
- **Weeks 7–12:** 2 auctions + 1 farmers' day worked; first co-op conversation; compatibility matrix v1 published; 100 registered farms.
- **Asks:** Android testers now; intros to cattle farmers (any scale, any district); the district auction calendar.

Sources for market claims: AgriOrbit (LITS-SA status), Food For Mzansi (FMD traceability costs), African Farming (Studbook IDTrax, May 2026), DALRRD LITS policy document, National Treasury eTenders LITS procurement (June 2026). Herd and farm counts are ordered estimates from public statistics.